

Safe and secure

Perhaps the first thing people think of when they decide to open a bank account is that it's a safe place to keep their money, locked away in the vaults of a secure building. But today there's comparatively little cash in the banks, and the accounts consist of numbers in a computer program—but it's still safer than having the cash in your pocket. The main reason most people have a bank account is for convenience. Although some people still get paid at the end of the week or month in cash or by check, which they can deposit into the bank, more and more employers transfer their workers' pay directly into their bank accounts. And while small businesses are often paid in cash for their goods or services, customers are increasingly choosing to buy things using debit or credit cards. So, for most people earning money, it's essential to have a bank account.

**IF YOU WOULD BE WEALTHY, THINK
OF SAVING AS WELL AS GETTING.**

BENJAMIN FRANKLIN

Easy access

In addition to providing a place to put your income, banks offer different ways of dealing with your expenditure: the things you need to pay for. You can withdraw money, either over the counter at a branch of your bank, or from an ATM (automated teller machine). But you can also use your bank card to pay for things, in stores, by phone, or online. And you can ask the bank to make regular payments, such as rent or loan repayments, direct from your account. To help you track what's going in and out of your account, most